

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Biden blocks proposed Nippon deal

Union cheers move while 2 steel firms threaten lawsuit

By Fatima Hussein, Josh Boak and Marc Levy
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Joe Biden has blocked the nearly \$15 billion proposed deal for Nippon Steel of Japan to purchase

Pittsburgh-based U.S. Steel — affirming his vow on the campaign trail to prevent the acquisition of Steeltown USA's most storied company.

The bid kicked up a political maelstrom across America's industrial heartland.

"We need major U.S. companies representing the major share of U.S. steelmaking capacity to keep leading the fight on behalf of America's national interests,"

Biden said Friday morning.

Nippon Steel and U.S. Steel blasted the decision, saying in a joint statement that blocking the deal "reflects a clear violation of due process and the law" in a process it said was "manipulated" to advance Biden's political agenda.

It also insisted that Biden cited no credible evidence of the deal presenting a national security problem and suggested it will sue,

saying "we are left with no choice but to take all appropriate action to protect our legal rights."

Biden's decision comes after the Committee on Foreign Investment in the United States, known as CFIUS, failed to reach consensus last month on the possible national security risks of the deal and sent a long-awaited report on the merger to Biden. He had 15 days to reach a decision.

The committee, chaired by

Treasury Secretary Janet Yellen and made up of other Cabinet members, can recommend that the president block a transaction, and federal law gives the president that power.

A U.S. official familiar with the matter, who spoke on condition of anonymity, told The Associated Press last month that some federal agencies represented on the panel

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How Bears veteran Byard plays on

His 147th straight game awaits despite on-field losses, personal trials

By Colleen Kane
Chicago Tribune

Kevin Byard's first season with the Chicago Bears has been a challenge. The veteran safety won't dispute that. A midseason coach firing and a 10-game losing streak marred a year that started with much hope.

But Byard has a unique perspective on playing through the Bears' 2024 trials as he prepares to start his 17th game of the season Sunday against the Green Bay Packers at Lambeau Field.

It will be his 147th consecutive regular-season game played. Now in his ninth NFL season, Byard, 31, hasn't missed a game, aside from an October 2023 trade from the Tennessee Titans to the Philadelphia Eagles that resulted in his having two bye weeks.

The streak is a testament to his physical durability, his work to maintain his health — and a mental fortitude that has helped him persist despite considerable adversity.

Before Byard had to figure out how to navigate the most losses of his career with the 4-12 Bears, he played the previous two seasons while dealing with matters of death and extraordinary life.

"It's understanding that sometimes you're not always going to get the results that you want," Byard said Thursday at Halas Hall, "but you don't let a circumstance dictate how you approach each day. I've always tried to be an even-keeled guy, showing up every day for my guys — not only for my team but my family as well. So it's been a challenge.

"I've learned a lot from this, but you always just have to continue to persevere. Because the way I see it, the type of things I've been through in my personal life the past couple of years, those things are a lot harder than what I'm going through right now as far as on-the-field stuff."

Byard has had a more difficult time than most people know. His

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Trump sentencing set for Jan. 10

A judge Friday set President-elect Donald Trump's sentencing in his hush money case for Jan. 10 — little over a week before he's due to return to the White House — but indicated Trump wouldn't be jailed. **Nation & World**

Chicagoan finds her voice on debut album

Kristyn Chapman, who performs under the moniker Morpho, leans into an earnest approach to connect with listeners on her first release, a quality that has carried over to the stage. **Arts & Living**



ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

State trooper laid to rest

Illinois state troopers carry the casket of Trooper Clay Carns following his funeral at Parkview Christian Church in Orland Park on Friday. Carns was struck and killed by a vehicle while on duty, cleaning up debris on Interstate 55 near Channahon on Dec. 23, police said. **Story, Page 3.**



Chicago Public Schools parent Mike Ngan reads with his daughters Verity, 9, and Rozzy, 3, at their home in the Lincoln Square neighborhood on Friday. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

The post-winter break blues

Parents and educators voice worry about CPS' future, and are divided about Martinez's ouster

By Ikram Mohamed
Chicago Tribune

Heading back to classes Monday, Chicago Public School students will return to a district different from the one they left for winter break.

It's been just over two weeks since the Chicago Board of Education unanimously voted to oust CEO Pedro Martinez. The monthslong conflict reached a boiling point on the last day of school before winter break, when dozens of speak-

ers stood before Martinez at a special board meeting, ridiculing him and telling him his "time has finally come."

"I hope you never forget any of the students at (Marine Leadership Academy) and those who were affected by your lack of integrity, professionalism, accountability and lack of empathy and ethics," said Luz Sarama referring to what she alleged was Martinez's inaction regarding "abuse of power," misuse of funds and "mental and physical harm" of

students at the school.

While many of the two dozen speakers at the meeting expressed their disdain for the CEO — several among them parents of CPS students and graduates — others who spoke to the Tribune after Martinez's ouster say they disagree with the board's decision.

Anna Pavichevich, a retired CPS principal with a long family lineage in the district, said she is concerned what this kind of leadership change could mean for CPS.

Pavichevich said she is "stunned by the complete and

Turn to CPS, Page 3

Bally's starts \$250M IPO for minority investors

Casino site demolition remains on hold after Chicago River spill

By Robert Channick
Chicago Tribune

When Bally's won the competitive bidding process nearly three years ago to build Chicago's first casino, it pledged to give minority investors a piece of the action as part of its agreement with the city.

This week, Bally's Chicago launched an initial public offering for women and minorities to buy a 25% equity stake in the fledgling casino, looking to fulfill its obligation to the city and raise funds for the construction of its proposed \$1.7 billion entertainment complex in River West, which is slated to open in September 2026.

But as applications begin to flow in through an online investor portal, work at the 30-acre site, home to what's left of the former Chicago Tribune printing plant, remains halted after a demolition mishap last month that spilled debris from a wall into the adjacent Chicago River.

"Our goal is to start full-fledged demolition as soon as possible," Chris Jewett, Bally's senior vice president of corporate development, said Thursday. "It's imminent."

The river has since been cleaned

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